

Introduction to Sociocultural Anthropology (AN101)

Location: 565 Commonwealth Ave KCB 101

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Course Description

This course will introduce you to anthropological and ethnographic approaches to the study of cultural, social, and linguistic life across the world. Our semester will provide you with a foundation for understanding historical and contemporary contexts related to: the local and the global (and the ways we live across and between them); migration, immigration, travel, and diaspora; ethnic, racial, and class identities and the ways our worlds and our behaviors may be shaped around and by them (with or without our knowledge); political economy, systems of exchange, power, and governance; work and play; nature and built environments; the human and the non-human; health and illness; the “good life”; and systems of belief and meaning-making.

One of the key goals of this course is to help students open up their own “anthropological imaginations.” Anthropology, the study of people, allows us to make “strange” those behaviors and beliefs that seem familiar, and to make things that are familiar to us seem exotic or strange. It allows us to challenge our own preconceptions of the world and to learn how to engage with a variety of cultures, with the knowledge that we too are shaped by (and shape) culture(s).

Studying anthropology can help you as you pursue almost any career path, including education, health care, journalism, marketing, business, and many others. It can also you better navigate the

relationships that are meaningful in your own lives. It will also surely change the way you travel, eat, shop, and understand why people do what they do.

Your learning, understanding, and critical thinking in this course will be evaluated through various methods including a mid-term exam, a final exam, course activities and discussions, and your own mini-ethnographic observation exercises.

Student Learning Outcomes

By the end of the class, students will be able to:

- *Identify and describe key anthropological perspectives*, especially cultural relativity; negotiation of identity and “Othering”; space and place; kinship and social systems; and representational practices;
- *Explain identity, culture, and community* as dynamic processes situated in history, context, and individual creativity, between structure and agency;
- *Utilize anthropological perspectives* to reflect on and think critically about current events and processes in the world. Students will understand the importance of context and perspective on understanding not only others, but also (and especially) ourselves and our own contexts. Anthropology provides powerful tools for examining our own lives and beliefs through contrast and comparison. We see how things are by imagining how they could be otherwise.

Course Materials

- All readings/podcasts/videos will be available through our course website

Course Requirements

Engagement and Participation (15% of grade):

Our class time together consists of both lecture and discussion sections, both of which are essential to learning and processing the class material. Your participation and quality of engagement depends on your having read and reflected on the readings for each week. Attendance is required and will occasionally be taken. Consistently poor attendance (i.e., missing a majority of check-ins) will affect your participation grade.

However, please take care of yourselves and attend to your responsibilities and well-being: **missing up to three section meetings will have no effect on your grade.** Please be in touch with me and your TF if you anticipate missing classes; I am here to support you and will work with you to make sure you stay caught up.

Midterm Exam (20%):

Your midterm exam, covering the first half of our semester, will contain multiple choice, select all that apply, matching, short answer, and essay questions. Your midterm exam will be taken in class.

Final Exam (25%):

Your final exam will be comprehensive and will contain multiple choice, select all that apply, matching, short answer, and essay questions. Your final exam will be taken during the final exam week established by the department at a time and place TBD. The final exam is an opportunity for you to put together various parts of the class in ways that are meaningful for you.

Ethnographic Journals (40% of grade):

This assignment gives you the opportunity to practice observing and describing social life in the U.S. like an anthropologist. A series of specific, observational, reflective, and writing activities will be assigned throughout the semester. Your journal entries will be collected at three intervals listed on the course calendar. An ethnographic journal analysis will be due during finals week. We will discuss these assignments in more detail during class, and grading rubrics will be made available on Blackboard.

Ethnographic Journal #1 (due February 20th by 11:59 PM)

Observation of space & place: this assignment includes two (typed & single-spaced) or three (handwritten**) pages of fieldnotes and a 400–500-word reflection

Ethnographic Journal #2 (due March 20th by 11:59 PM)

Interview at your field site: this assignment includes one page (typed or handwritten**) of fieldnotes, a list of your open-ended questions (at least 5) and your informant's answers, and a 300-word reflection

Ethnographic Journal #3 (due April 10th by 11:59 PM)

Observation of a material object from your field site: this assignment includes a short video or photographic show and tell, one page of fieldnotes, and a 400–500-word reflection on your object

Final Ethnographic Journal Analysis (due May 2nd at 11:59 PM)

A final synthesis of your ethnographic research this semester (500–700 words)

****Note on handwritten fieldnotes:** Handwritten fieldnotes must be legible and uploaded in a format that your instructor can read. If your handwritten fieldnotes are not legible, please type them. Illegible fieldnotes will not be graded.

Note on fieldwork ethics: You will be taking notes about the interactions and activities you observe for this assignment. Anthropologists follow a code of ethics that includes the imperative to do no harm. You are expected to follow basic ethical guidelines as you complete this project. DO NOT write about any illegal activities (hazing, underage drinking, sexual harassment, etc.). Most importantly, you do not have the proper training to undertake such research responsibly. Your teaching team is also legally obligated to report any illegal activities to the university administration.

Note on extensions: An automatic 24-hour extension is granted to all students for these written assignments. However, extensions will not be granted for the midterm or final exam. If you find yourself in a position in which you have to miss an exam, please be in touch with me ASAP.

AI Policy: AI is very useful to researchers in gathering information about how others have answered questions or approached problems. You are permitted to use AI **to gather information**; any information gathered using AI must then be substantially transformed, deepened, and taken in new directions in your own work. This is where learning occurs, and where you add to the pool of knowledge that AI draws upon. Please remember that ChatGPT often gives information that is

incorrect, including citations.

Please do not submit an essay written in part or in whole by AI; this is a violation of course rules and constitutes academic dishonesty. Your teaching team uses AI as well, and we are familiar with what kind of work it can produce.

If you do use AI, please include a very short description (2-3 sentences) of how you used it and how it was useful.

Two Extra Credit Opportunities + Optional Creative Project:

Book Club

You will have the opportunity to join one or more book clubs throughout the semester with your peers. To receive the extra credit, you will be required to attend and contribute to a short book club meeting with colleagues. You can only join one book club for the semester for credit. Dates and times for these book clubs will be publicized later on in the semester, at which point you will have the opportunity to sign up.

The books to choose among include (with possible modification): *Of Boys and Men* (Richard Reeves), *The Undocumented Americans* (Karla Cornejo Villavicencio), *Mohawk Interruptus* (Audra Simpson), *Wisdom Sits in Places* (Keith Basso).

Creative Piece

If interested, you will also have the opportunity to produce a creative project (visual art, fiction, poetry, blog entry) in conversation with the book you have read or the film you watched for additional points, or a local exhibit (to be selected by the teaching team during the semester).

Grading Scale

A	94 and above
A-	90–93
B+	87–89
B	83–86
B-	80–82
C+	77–79
C	73–76
C-	70–72
D	60–69
Failing	59 and below

COURSE SCHEDULE AND READINGS

Please note that this syllabus is **subject to change** at any time, in response to student interest and at the teaching team's discretion;
the most up-to-date version will be found on our Blackboard site

Please complete the following tasks by the date under which they are listed

Week 1: Introduction: Representation, Knowledge, & Authority

WEDNESDAY (January 21st)

Course introduction

There are no readings for our first class meeting

FRIDAY (January 23rd)

READ: Horace Miner, "Body Rituals among the Nacirema," *American Anthropologist* 58 (1956): 503–7.

Optional (for further reading): Laura Bohannan, "Shakespeare in the Bush," *Natural History* (August/September 1966), <https://www.naturalhistorymag.com/picks-from-the-past/12476/shakespeare-in-the-bush>.

Week 2: Where is the Discipline coming from? Fieldwork, Insiders, Outsiders

MONDAY (January 26th)

READ: Bronislaw Malinowski, "Introduction: The Subject, Method and Scope of this Enquiry," in *Argonauts of the Western Pacific: An Account of Native Enterprise and Adventure in the Archipelagoes of Melanesian New Guinea* (Routledge: 1922), 1–26.

WEDNESDAY (January 28th)

READ: Franz Boas, "A Year Among the Eskimo," in *The Boas Reader* (Basic Book: 1974), 44–55.

Optional: Louis Menard, "How Cultural Anthropologists Redefined Humanity," *The New Yorker*, 2019.

Franz Boas, "The Shackles of Tradition," <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GOvFDioPrMM>.

FRIDAY (January 30th)

LISTEN TO: "High Voltage (Emotions Part 2)," *Invisibilia*, June 22, 2017, <https://www.wnyc.org/story/57afe9b901172c46d9d37cd3/>.

Or, in place of the podcast if you prefer a written text: Renato Rosaldo, "Grief and a Headhunter's Rage," in *The Day of Shelly's Death: The Poetry and Ethnography of Grief* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2014), 117–35.

Week 3: *Doing Cultural Anthropology: Fieldwork, Insiders, Outsiders*

MONDAY (February 2nd)

READ: Edward Said, “Introduction,” (Parts I & II **only**), in *Orientalism* (Vintage Press/Pantheon Books, 1978).

READ: Laura Nader, “Up the Anthropologist” [part III, pgs 5–10, and part V, pgs 17–19 only]

WEDNESDAY (February 4th)

LISTEN TO: Zora Neale Hurston, “Introduction” and “chapter 1,” in *Mules and Men*.

The physical audiobook is currently on reserve at the library (to be consulted in person).

You can also find the **online audiobook** here:

https://bu.leganto.exlibrisgroup.com/leganto/public/01BOSU_INST/lists/38421952580001161?auth=SAML .

Listen from the beginning to minute 28:19.

Audiobook is preferred; however, if you would like to follow along on the text (or simply prefer to read), you can find it also on Blackboard.

Note: *This book was written in the 1930s and features words that Black Americans then used to describe themselves. Hurston’s work, in line with her intellectual investments and political positions, maintains the language in use at the time. As these are no longer terms of self-description, we will not use them in class, but we will discuss in more depth the questions raised here—about ownership of language, about the reclaiming of slurs—in our weeks on religion and language.*

Optional: Kirin Narayan, “How Native is a ‘Native’ Anthropologist?,” *American Anthropologist* 95 (1993): 1–16.

FRIDAY (February 6th)

No class – Please meet during class time in your small groups

In place of today’s lecture, you will meet with your small groups to do your Nacirema “Insider Anthropologist” exercise. Please post your write-up on Blackboard by 11:59 PM tonight, and please comment on two other groups’ posts (see Blackboard assignment for more details)

Week 4: *Culture as a Concept & its Limitations; Kinship*

MONDAY (February 9th)

READ: Raymonde Carroll, “Home” and “Conversation,” in *Cultural Misunderstandings: The French-American Experience* (Chicago: University of Chicago, 1988), 13–39.

WEDNESDAY (February 11th)

READ: Clifford Geertz, “Deep Play: Notes on a Balinese Cockfight,” in *The Interpretation of Culture* (Basic Books, 1973)/Daedalus (Fall 2005), 55–65, 71–74, 78–86.

FRIDAY (February 13th) [*Kinship and Family*]

READ: David Schneider, “The Fundamental Assumption in the Study of Kinship,” in *A Critique of the Study of Kinship*, ed. David Schneider (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1984), 165–77.

[Note that David Schneider is disagreeing with a lot of other anthropologists, whose arguments he will outline in depth.]

Pay attention to why he is criticizing these other anthropologists; *what did they get wrong? Don't get too lost in the details of the arguments—stick to the big-picture questions.*]

In-Class: Short session on journal #1

Week 5: Kinship & Family

MONDAY (February 16)

No class, President's Day

TUESDAY (February 17th)

Replacement class—Monday schedule

READ: Eli Baden-Lasar, "I'm 20. I have 32 Half Siblings. This is My Family Portrait," *The New York Times Magazine*, June 30, 2019.

WEDNESDAY (February 18)

READ: Briallen Hopper, *Hard to Love: Essays & Confessions* (Bloomsbury: 2019), 50–58 **only**.

READ: Kim Tallbear, "Making Love and Relations Beyond Settler Sex and Family," in *Making Kin Not Population* (Chicago: Prickly Paradigm Press, 2018), 145–57 **only**.

Optional: Dr. Kim Tallbear, "On Reviving Kinship and Sexual Abundance," April 22, 2022, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hGxDtuFA3Xw>.

FRIDAY (February 20)

READ: Joanna Davidson and Dinah Hannaford, eds., *Opting Out: Women Messing with Marriage Around the World* (Rutgers: 2023). [Excerpt]
Guest Lecture

Optional: Sienna Craig, *The Ends of Kinship* (University of Washington Press: 2020). [Part IV: "Introduction" and "At the Threshold of this Life"].

ETHNOGRAPHIC JOURNAL 1 due by 11:59 PM on February 20th

Observation of space & place— this assignment includes two (typed & single-spaced) or three (handwritten) pages of fieldnotes and a 400-500-word reflection

Week 6: The State, Structure, & Agency: Thinking with, against, outside of Institutions

MONDAY (February 23rd)

READ: James C. Scott, "Cities, People and Language," in *The Anthropology of the State: A Reader*, ed. Aradhana Sharma and Akhil Gupta (Malden: Blackwell, 2008), 247–69.

WEDNESDAY (February 25th)

READ: Seth Holmes, "Chapter 1," in *Fresh Fruit, Broken Bodies* (University of California: 2013).

Optional:

Jason, De León, *The Land of Open Graves: Living and Dying on the Migrant Trail* (Los Angeles: University of California Press, 2015), pp. 1-37 (including a critique of Holmes).

FRIDAY (February 27th)

READ: Anne Allison, “Japanese Mothers and Obentos: The Lunchbox as Ideological State Apparatus,” *Anthropological Quarterly* (1991): 195–208.

READ: Claudio Sopranzetti, *The King of Bangkok* (University of Toronto, 2021) [Excerpt]

Week 7: Gender and SexualityMONDAY (March 2nd)

READ: Sherry Ortner, “Is Female as to Male as Nature is to Culture?” *Feminist Studies* 1, no. 2 (1972): 5–31.

READ: Marilyn Strathern, “One Man Many Men,” in *Big Men and Great Men* (Cambridge, 1991) [excerpt].

READ: Robert Putnam and Richard Reeves, “The Boys Are Not OK,” *The New York Times*, August 15, 2025, <https://www.nytimes.com/2025/08/15/opinion/men-boys-crisis-progressive-era.html>.

Optional: “The Boys Are Not Okay,” *The Culture Desk*, NYTimes Podcast, May 22, 2025, <https://www.nytimes.com/2025/05/22/podcasts/the-boys-are-not-ok.html>.

WEDNESDAY (March 4th)

READ: Emily Martin, “The Egg and the Sperm: How Science Has Constructed a Romance Based on Stereotypical Male-Female Roles,” *Signs* 16, no. 13 (1991): 485–501.

READ: Gabrielle Stanley Blair, *Ejaculate Responsibly: a whole new way to think about abortion* (New York: Workman Publishing, 2022) [Excerpt]

FRIDAY (March 6th)**In-Class Midterm**

SPRING BREAK: March 7th–15th

Week 8: Religion, Meaning Making, & Borrowing versus AppropriationMONDAY (March 16th)

READ: TBD

In-class: Tales from the field by Syeda Rumana Mehdi

WEDNESDAY (March 18th)

READ: Emile Durkheim, “Chapter 7” (Excerpt), in *Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1995) [focus on pgs 217–229].

FRIDAY (March 20th)

READ: Liz Bucar, “Chapter 2: Playing Pilgrim,” in *Stealing My Religion* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2022, pgs. 127–34 only.

LISTEN TO: Liz Bucar, Classical Ideas Podcast: <https://classicalideaspodcast.libsyn.com/ep-251-stealing-my-religion-wdr-liz-bucar>.

ETHNOGRAPHIC JOURNAL 2 due on March 20th by 11:59 PM

Interview at your field site—this assignment includes one page (typed or handwritten) of fieldnotes, a list of your open-ended questions (at least 5) and your informant's answers, and a 300-word reflection

Week 9: Race, Class, and Chosen/Unchosen Identity

MONDAY (March 23rd)

READ: Justin García, "Race and Ethnicity" from *Perspectives*.

<https://perspectives.pressbooks.com/chapter/race-and-ethnicity/>.

WATCH: "A Conversation with White People on Race." *NYTimes*. 1 July 2015.

https://www.nytimes.com/2015/07/01/opinion/a-conversation-with-white-people-on-race.html?rref=collection%2Fcolumn%2Fop-docs&action=click&contentCollection=opinion®ion=stream&module=stream_unit&version=se-arch&contentPlacement=2&pgtype=collection.

WEDNESDAY (March 25th)

READ: Susan Falls, "'Redneck Customs': race and class at the demolition derby," *Leisure Studies* 32, vol. 4 (2013): 429–445.

WATCH: "Tammy's Story." *People Like Us*. 2001.

<https://amara.org/videos/utDFYTEtI3es/info/tammys-story-people-like-us-episode-4/>

Optional: "Barbara Kingsolver Thinks Urban Liberals Have It All Wrong on Appalachia," *The Ezra Klein Show*.

FRIDAY (March 27th)

READ: Pierre Bourdieu, *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgment of Taste*, trans. Richard Nice (Harvard University: 1987). **[Excerpt only, do not read crossed-out sections.]**

*Note: *this piece looks long but it is not!* To pay attention to: **habitus, taste in food, taste in sports**

Week 10: Economics, Exchange & the Commodity

MONDAY (March 30th)

READ: Karl Marx, "Chapter 1: Commodities," in *Capital: critique of political economy*, vol. 1 (1977), in *The Marx and Engels Reader*, **ONLY 302–308, 319–329** (you can skim 308–319 if you would like, but it is not required).

WEDNESDAY (April 1st)

READ: Marcel Mauss, *The Gift*, trans. Ian Cunnison (WW Norton: 1967), 1–10.

LISTEN TO: "Money 2.0: Emotional Currency," *Hidden Brain*, 2015,

<https://hiddenbrain.org/podcast/money-2-0-emotional-currency/>.

FRIDAY (April 3rd)

READ: David Graeber, "On the Phenomenon of Bullshit Jobs," *Strike! Magazine* (2013),

<https://www.strike.coop/bullshit-jobs/>.

READ: Barbara Ehrenreich, *Nickel and Dimed* (Picador, 2001) [Excerpt].

Week 11: *Bodies, Animals, Humans, Subjects*

MONDAY (April 6th)

READ: Carol Adams, “‘A very rare and difficult thing’: Ecofeminism, Attention to Animal Suffering, and the Disappearance of the Subject,” in *A Communion of Subjects: Animals in Religion, Science and Ethics*, ed. Paul Waldau and Kimberley Patton (New York: Columbia University, 2006).

Optional:

Piers Locke, “Elephants as Persons, Affective Apprenticeship, and Fieldwork with Nonhuman Informants in Nepal,” *HAAU: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 7 no. 1 (2017): 353–76.

WEDNESDAY (April 8th)

WATCH: The Rights of Nature: A Global Movement (2018, 54 mins) by Issac Goeckeritz.

READ: Vanessa Chang, *The Body Digital: A History of Humans and Machines from Cuckoo Clocks to ChatGPT* (Penguin, 2025) [Excerpt].

Optional: “How ‘Being Animal’ Could Help Us Be Better Humans,” *The Ezra Klein Show*.

OR

Radhika Govindrajana, *Animal Intimacies* (Chicago: University of Chicago, 2018).

FRIDAY (April 10th)

READ: Philippe Bourgois and Jeff Schonberg, *Righteous Dopefiend* (University of California: 2009). [Introduction]

ETHNOGRAPHIC JOURNAL 3 due on April 10th by 11:59 PM

Week 12: *Space, Time, and Sound*

MONDAY (April 13th)

READ: Anne Meneley, *Tournaments of Value: Sociability and Hierarchy in a Yemeni Town*. University of Toronto: 1996. [pgs. 27–36, 39–41, 100–104 + [skim](#) preface for information on fieldwork & author's photos]

Optional: Yu-Fi Tuan, *Space and Place* [Excerpt]

ETHNOGRAPHIC JOURNAL 3 due on April 13th by 11:59 PM

WEDNESDAY (April 15th)

READ: Michael D. Jackson, *The Varieties of Temporal Experience* (New York: Columbia University, 2018) [“The Enigma of Anteriority” pgs 129–136].

READ: David J Silverman, “Introduction.” *This Land is Their Land: The Wampanoag Indians, Plymouth Colony, and the Troubled History of Thanksgiving* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2019) 1–21 [you may disregard crossed-out sections].

Optional (for further reading): Ralph Lawrence (2014), *Renegade Dreams: Living through Injury in Gangland Chicago* [Excerpt].

FRIDAY (April 17th)

READ: Mariam Goshadze, “The Varieties of Sonic Experience: ‘Quiet’ versus ‘not-noise’ in a Ghanaian harvest festival,” *American Anthropologist* 124, vol. 1 (2022): 165–74.

Week 13: *Ritual, Representation, and Language*

MONDAY (April 20)

No Class (Patriots’ Day)

WEDNESDAY (April 22nd) [Note today is a *Monday* schedule]

READ: Mucahit Bilici, “Muslim Ethnic Comedy: Inversions of Islamophobia,” in *Islamophobia/Islamophilia: Beyond the Politics of Enemy and Friend* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2010).

FRIDAY (April 24th)

READ: Vershawn Ashanti Young, “Should Writers Use They Own English?” *Iowa Journal of Cultural Studies*, vol 1, issue 10 (2010), <https://liberalarts.tamu.edu/english/wp-content/uploads/sites/17/2021/01/Use-They-Own.pdf>.

READ: Jane Hill, “Language, Race, and White Public Space.” *American Anthropologist* 100, vol. 3 (1998): 680–89.

WATCH: This Is How I Talk,” Saturday Night Live, May 17, 2015, *YouTube*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f8PXvqYpGCM>.

Optional: NPR. “The Godfather and the Limits of Representation.” *Pop Culture Happy Hour*. <https://www.npr.org/transcripts/1133013484>.

Further resources: [How Y’all, Youse and You Guys Talk](#). (log in through the library).

Week 14: *Language as Descriptive, Generative, or Diagnostic?*

MONDAY (April 27th)

READ: Lila Abu-Lughod, “Part Two: Discourses on Sentiment,” in *Veiled Sentiments* (Berkeley: University of California, 1988), ONLY 222–32.

Please note that the entire chapter is provided, though you are only required to read 222–232.

WEDNESDAY (April 29th)

READ: Current AAA Statement on Ethics (2012), <http://ethics.americananthro.org/category/statement/>

WATCH: Human Terrain: War Becomes Academic (2010), 82 mins, available online at the BU library (<https://video-alexanderstreet-com.ezproxy.bu.edu/watch/human-terrain-2>)

FINAL ETHNOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS, due May 2nd at 11:59 PM

A final synthesis of your ethnographic research this semester (500–700 words)

FINAL CUMULATIVE EXAM, DATE TBD (Date announced by Registrar)